PRATHAM BOOKS

ಮಳೆ ಬಂತು!

Male Bantu! (Rain Is Here!)

Shobha Hegde
Illustrated by Kiran Shenoy

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Arivu Kendra sample edition · Government of Karnataka

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CHAPTER 1

ಕಪ್ಪೆ

A rhyming picture book for the youngest readers. As the rain arrives, the frog, the peacock, the buffalo and the children of the village each greet it in their own way. Big, bold Kannada words on every page make this an ideal first book to read alone.

The morning began the way most mornings in the village did: with the temple bell carried across the fields, the smell of woodsmoke from the first kitchen fires, and the crows arguing on the tamarind tree about who had slept where. Nobody paid the crows much attention, except for one small person who was already awake and already wondering.

Ajji said that stories were like water. You could not hold them in your hands, but you could carry them in a pot, and if you were careful you could pour a little for everyone who came to the door. She said this while shelling peas, which was how she said most of the important things.

There is a road that goes out of the village past the pump house and the broken cart, and if you follow it far enough it turns into a path, and the path turns into a track between two fields, and the track ends at a stone where the hill begins. Everyone knows the stone. Not everyone has sat on it.

The rain, when it came, did not come all at once. First the dust lifted, then the leaves turned their pale sides up, then a single drop landed on the tin roof of the ration shop with a sound like a struck bell. After that, nobody could count.

“You cannot keep it,” said the old woman, not unkindly. “But you can remember it. That is what people are for.” And she handed back the pot, which was empty, and which was somehow heavier than before.

CHAPTER 2

ನವಿಲು

By evening the whole village had heard. The postman told the tailor, the tailor told the women at the well, and the women at the well told the children, who had known since the morning but were polite enough to act surprised.

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